

Hume's v/s Kant's Morality

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(Emotivism v/s Rationalism)

Is it bad to slap someone? To lie? To steal? Most of us would agree that these things are "bad" - they are "immoral". But what does it mean to be moral, to be right or to be immoral, to be wrong? The question of morality has been a fundamental question of human existence and perhaps it first would have emerged when the first "aware humans" interacted b/w each other. Religion has played a critical role in defining the principals of ethics, though I would argue the causal relationship b/w religion and morality, for many soiths one could easily say that the morality existed first and it birthed the religion or atleast the need for religion. The question of morality also sits at the center of the question of consciousness and cosmological arguments that we discussed in the first two chapters. For all the efforts of mystics, intellectuals, scientists, to this day, the question of morality remains an open question.

However, in the modern times, two philosophers have managed to propose promising yet contradictory theories to the human's need to define morality.

David Hume with his empiricism - the view that all knowledge is based on experience and emotivism and Immanuel Kant with noumena and categorical imperative.

Hume' argues that all morality is based on sentiments. He wrote that "Reason is, and ought to be, the slave of the passion". All reason is, is a vessel for desires and moral judgement comes primarily from human feelings and sympathy. To Hume, stealing is immoral because it leads to the feeling of disgust and sympathy for the person/victim who is stolen. It is the collection reaction/emotion that a particular action arises that decides the morality of an action. We see this in action all the time, ask people what do they think about killing insects and you would very easily find the the moral judgement is different for the killing of a butterfly and a caterpillar or for killing of a cat and a sheep. When you witness this, you cannot, but wonder if Hume was right and all moral judgest is the emotional reaction dressed up as reason. Hume argues that reason is in itself a means for desire, it does not tell us what to want, but rather defines how to get this.

Kant was deeply troubled by this theory of Hume, he spent years reaching it since it dealt a huge blow to Kant's personal & religious believes. It somehow subjectivized the morality, the distinction

b/w ~~to~~ right and wrong. In the absence of an objective morality, what role does the religion possibly play but be a tool for the desires as Hume proclaimed. Kant spent years in trouble and trying to come up with a coherent reply. This was the time in history when Newton was revolutionizing the world of science by discovering the fundamental physical laws and Kant wondered if such laws could be formulated in the metaphysics as well. To have moral laws that are true across cultures, space and time. He ultimately came up with the theory that "the only good thing is a good will" — an inherently abrahamic idea that actions are defined by their intention.

Kant's main idea was the categorical imperative:

"Act only according to a maxim that you could consistently will to become a universal law".

It's essentially the centuries old rule that do unto others, what you would wish to see common. A Mafia boss who kills people ~~he~~ would never want a world in which killing is the norm, he himself would hate to be get killed when coming back from his murder assignment. He knows that the maxim should not be a universal law, yet he draws exception for himself and according to Kant this process of drawing exception makes the act an immoral act. Same could be said

for tax returns. We don't want anyone to lie on their tax returns, but we ourselves wouldn't mind lying to save money — ~~for~~ wishing an exception to this rule and thus rendering the act immoral.

Another distinctive element as discussed before is "will / intention". Consider two cases; Case A where someone sitting on a window intentionally drops his laptop with the "intention" of killing someone. Case B where the laptop is dropped as an "accident" / unintentionally and ~~to~~ drops on someone's head and kills him. Now according to Hume's framework, the two cases are almost identical and equally immoral since both arouses disgust / disapproval and feeling of sympathy for the victim (it may be argued that knowing the drop was unintentional in case 2 slightly reduces the feeling of disgust, but forgoing that detail for now). But for Kant the two cases are completely different and in fact the person who dropped without a will (unintentionally) is completely blameless.

Perhaps, one interesting aspect is the categorical imperative of Kant and hypothetical imperative of Hume. For Hume, the desires set the end and reason / action is means to that, thus hypothetical imperative — "Do X if you want Y"

Categorical Imperatives, on the other hand, establish fundamental duties of all "rational actors" and takes the shape of "Do X because it is right". It is something you must do because it is morally right.

Trying to decide b/w these 2 theories is like playing quantum mechanics with morality. The more sharply you try to ascertain, the less confident you get. We saw the examples with insects demonstrating the obvious nature of Hume's theory. Now consider this, we all learn and teach Kantian morality all the time, to every child in kindergarden. Let's say Ali and Fatima are 6 years old and playing, Ali being the stronger seizes Fatima's doll. Now every adult would tell Ali that it is wrong! & it is wrong because what if everyone starts using force to seize others' toys. Hamza is stronger, what if he seizes Ali's toy, would he like it? Probably not. We just taught and applied Kant's morality to a 6 year old and we do this all the time, our rules, constitutions are primarily based of categorical imperative and concept of "will". It can be because we really do believe Kant's theory or it might be that we follow Kant's rational theory to feel reasonable and feel good about ourselves (Hume's wink). And ~~we~~ how many times we see the champions of morality lowering their logic when brown kids get killed in Gaza instead of in Europe, or the thousand rational/legal loopholes for the rich and pretty, (Again Hume's wink).